

Incident handler's journal

Scenario

A small U.S. health care clinic specializing in delivering primary-care services experienced a security incident on a Tuesday morning, at approximately 9:00 a.m. Several employees reported that they were unable to use their computers to access files like medical records. Business operations shut down because employees were unable to access the files and software needed to do their jobs. Additionally, employees also reported that a ransom note was displayed on their computers. The ransom note stated that all the company's files were encrypted by an organized group of unethical hackers who are known to target organizations in healthcare and transportation industries. In exchange for restoring access to the encrypted files, the ransom note demanded a large sum of money for the decryption key. The attackers were able to gain access into the company's network by using targeted phishing emails, which were sent to several employees of the company. The phishing emails contained a malicious attachment that installed malware on the employees' computers once it was downloaded. Once the attackers gained access, they deployed their ransomware, which encrypted critical files. The company was unable to access critical patient data, causing major disruptions in their business operations. The company was forced to shut down their computer systems and contact several organizations to report the incident and receive technical assistance.

Date: Record the date of the journal entry.	Entry: 10/12/2024
Description	Documenting a ransomware attack that disrupted operations at a small U.S. health care clinic.
Tool(s) used	None
The 5 W's	● Who caused the incident? A group of cybercriminals known for targeting the healthcare and transportation sectors. ● What happened? A ransomware attack encrypted important company files, locking employees out of critical systems and demanding a ransom in exchange for a decryption key. ● When did the incident occur? Tuesday morning at approximately 9:00 a.m. ● Where did the incident happen? At a small U.S.-based health-care clinic that provides primary-care services. ● Why did the incident happen? The attackers used phishing emails containing malicious attachments to gain unauthorized access to the network. After gaining access, they launched ransomware that encrypted critical files, likely motivated by financial gain.

Additional notes	To avoid future incidents, the clinic should strengthen its email security by using better spam filters and running phishing awareness training for employees. Installing endpoint detection and regularly backing up data can also help reduce the impact of future attacks. It's generally advised not to pay the ransom, as it doesn't guarantee data recovery and can encourage more attacks. Instead, the clinic should focus on recovering from backups and working with cybersecurity professionals and law enforcement.
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